

Citizen Manmohan

When he is not signing files, the prime minister catches up with his family and Urdu poetry

*Main akela hi chala tha jaanib-e-manzil magar,
Log saath aate gaye aur karwaan banta gaya.*

(I was walking alone towards my destination. People joined me and it became a crowd.)

While it is easy to see why Manmohan Singh is so fond of quoting this particular couplet, his political speeches give an insight to a private passion. The economist is a romantic at heart and loves to tune into some Urdu poetry when he is not crunching inflation vs income growth figures. Mirza Ghalib is a favourite.

Singh's simplicity tends to run into predictable patterns. He always wears a light blue turban with his crisp kurtas and sometimes a Nehru jacket. Of course there are some who see this a Gandhi straitjacket! He always uses a favourite silver Cross pen to sign files. Wife Gursharan Kaur undertakes politically correct social causes, like promoting awareness against breast cancer. Has three daughters, all of whom have written books. His youngest Amrit, in fact, wrote a book criticising George Bush when her dad was negotiating the nuke deal.

In his private life, he remains more of Citizen Manmohan than prime minister. When he wants to get his driving licence renewed, he goes to the RTO like any other citizen. The prime minister is fond of the occasional cup of tea, accompanied with Marie biscuits. A frugal eater, as is apparent from his choice of biscuits, he opts for grilled foods and sugar-free desserts. So careful is he to avoid oily dishes that an aide disclosed that once while abroad for a multilateral summit, all he ate was curd and rice. Clearly this is one prime minister who knows all too well the political perils of biting off more than one can chew.



(FROM LEFT) GURSHARAN, MANMOHAN AND DAUGHTER UPINDER SINGH

is different," explains Anand Sharma, the I&B Minister. Sonia begins every speech explaining, praising and defending her choice. At a press conference in Delhi she said, "There are many aspirants but no one stands before Dr Manmohan Singhji. What else can I say?" At a rally in Bihar, she thundered: "Advaniji calls Manmohan Singhji a weak prime minister. What about his track record as home minister?" In rural Maharashtra she rhapsodised: "No one can match our prime minister in capability, experience and credibility. Please vote for our candidate."

Candidate Manmohan brings with him the right gloss to pose for the cover page of the party manifesto. "His integrity is unquestionable and he has delivered," says Congress General Secretary Digvijay Singh. Then there is the inspirational biography. "I grew up in a small village with no electricity, no roads and no safe water and had to

walk for miles to go to the nearest school. So as prime minister, I felt it was my duty to pay special attention to find solutions to mass poverty." That's how the prime minister narrates his rags-to-Race Course Road story. PMO officials joke about "inclusive growth", a phrase that always crops up in Manmohan's speeches. He says that it's not just political rhetoric, but it is something that can be done. For that he needs seven more years, or at the very least a second term. "If we ensure our economy grows at the rate of 9-10 per cent per annum, we can double the national income of our country in seven years," he

claims. What he does not explain is how he plans to achieve this in the age of global recession. The economist has not spelt out his economic vision for recovery.

Sundry salesmen of the Manmohan brand, though won't give up. "His counsel is sought by world leaders," beams Sharma, while another minister Ashwani Kumar says, "It is India's good fortune to have someone who understands fiscal management at its helm." "Economic management is an art. You must have at the steering wheel people who understand how the economy works. Only the Congress has the desired expertise," says Manmohan, his trademark shy smile almost slipping into a satisfied grin. Manmohanomics as the panacea for global

BRAND MANMOHAN HAS limited appeal. So he is being marketed in urban middle class centres that can understand his utility.